



Nodes Above 28nm Should Enter Commercial Production By 2028, 28nm Expected By 2029

SHRI AMITESH KUMAR SINHA, ADDITIONAL SECRETARY, MEITY, AND CEO OF ISM

Launched in 2021 and operationalised in 2022, the India Semiconductor Mission (ISM) is driving India's ambition to build a self-reliant semiconductor ecosystem spanning manufacturing, design, talent, and supply chains. In this exclusive interview, Dr Satya Gupta, President of the VLSI Society of India (VSI), speaks with Shri Amitesh Kumar Sinha, Additional Secretary, MeitY, and CEO of ISM, about the mission's progress, challenges, and roadmap for India's semiconductor future.

You have been associated with the ISM since its inception. Looking back over the past four-and-a-half years, how would you assess its progress, achievements, and key challenges?

The Union Cabinet approved the India Semiconductor Policy and the ISM on 15th December 2021, marking India's first comprehensive semiconductor policy backed by a long-term vision and strong commitment from Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi and the Union Minister of Electronics and Information Technology, Shri Ashwini Vaishnaw.

Our biggest challenge at the outset was the absence of a semiconductor ecosystem. Without one, attracting global manufacturers is

extremely difficult. The first proposals we received were not sufficiently convincing, and because semiconductor manufacturing is highly complex, particularly for a first-time entrant like India, we approved only those projects with a high probability of success.

To ensure this, we established rigorous evaluation criteria and constituted committees of global techno-commercial experts. Every project had to satisfy three non-negotiable requirements:

- **Strong financing.** Applicants needed deep financial strength backed by profitable or cash-rich parent companies capable of withstanding the cyclical nature of the semiconductor industry. Many early applicants were attracted primarily

by government incentives, so identifying genuinely committed partners took time.

- **Credible technology transfer.**

We required complete production-ready technology transfer rather than simple licensing agreements. This included equipment



PM Narendra Modi along with the leadership of Tata Sons and PSMC, September 2024